Lateral Networking

made for: the MEA Senior Project Course

at The University of Southern Mississippi



by Davy Goldsmith

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Davy Goldsmith

Let me tell you about myself

DIY writer, artist, musician, live event technician, audio/visual production.

Creator of *Hattiesburg Alternative*, a recurring music, arts, and literature zine highlighting local artists, writers, and musicians.

I work on campus at the Student Union complex doing live audio/visual for events hosted there.



Member of DSA and UCW and I support and volunteer at the Spectrum Center and the Mississippi Rising Coalition and the local punk scene.

Lateral Networking

what is it?

Lateral Networking is making voluntary connections between peers to work together as equals and to form long-term community built on mutual support.

It is not a substitute for Strategic Networking in modern capitalist society and appealing to employers and building vertical business relationships is still something you need to do.

But building community and forming peer-to-peer connections in a cooperative environment is good for your mental well-being while creating opportunities you'd otherwise not have.



what does this look like?

Finding similar interests or goals with your peer group

Starting projects with your peers using the resources and skills immediately accessible to you.

Understanding how to make meaningful impact with your audience

Taking ownership of your project before it is capitalized on or engineered by vertical producers



quick examples

a band
an indie/garage band

film
indie/small budget

screen printing
T-shirts and posters

publishing/small press
small scale printing and publishing

record label
recording and publishing music label

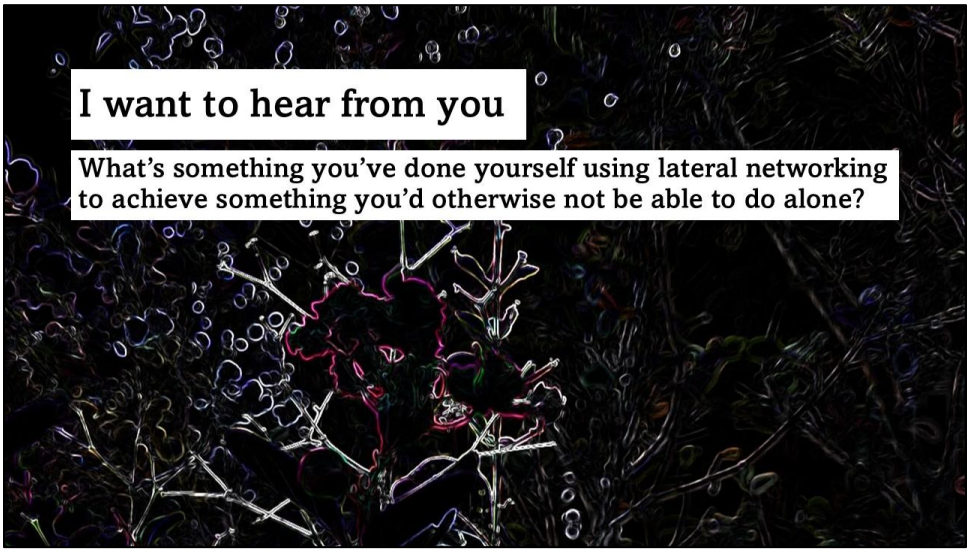
collaborative writing
workshops/split responsibilities

indie video games
development, coding, platforming

audio production
studio or live

video series
tiny desk

zine printing
small scale diy self-publishing





Frameworks

how your project is presented

Small Business Model

profit driven venture
relies on product or services sales

Non-Profit (501c3)

tax exempt charity
relies on tax-deductible donations

Do It Yourself

relies solely on the people directly involved
minimal expenses and funding



Do It Yourself

an earnest appeal

DIY prioritizes the completion of the project over using established methodologies and in doing so, you appeal directly to a base rather than gatekeepers in your industry.

DIY is about redefining success and is a rejection of professionalism for the good of yourself and the community.

It's not about what you can do. It's about who's going to stop you.

Ethos

Core Beliefs

Ethos or the core beliefs of the project give it its life allow it to reflect yourselves as the people behind it.

Ethos is important to retain the ethical direction of your work and to stay loyal to your base.



Ethos of DIY



Anti-racism and anti-authoritarianism – DIY actively counters the racism and fascism that curses our country and society.

Non-commercial – DIY should be either free or be raising funds for a good cause. The pursuit of profit hampers accessibility and influences content for popular consumption.

Informational – DIY should be practical and specialized to assist with self-reliance and to counter misinformation.

Community-centric – DIY forms bonds with like-minded individuals and contributes toward mutual aid to all those in need. It encourages cooperation beyond social norms.

Ethos of DIY



Anti-racism and anti-authoritarianism

Never include anything in your project that doesn't sit right with you. Whether that's anything racist, prejudiced, queerphobic, or otherwise targeted at putting down minority or vulnerable groups

Rage baiting and playing devil's advocate will only get you so far before your career ends in disgrace and you'll be surrounded by the most toxic people the whole time.

DIY is meant to build a platform for those who deserve it and don't otherwise have it and to challenge the establishment.

Ethos of DIY



Non-Commercial

Remember this is not a business venture. If you want to start a small business, that's totally fine, but commercializing your project just changes it from a community-centered effort to a for-profit venture.

And maybe income is something your zine needs to function as intended. Just realize you have a choice: to change the functionality of the zine to minimize the cost to an acceptable charitable loss or to start a business venture.

Ethos of DIY



Informational

In DIY you'll find a bunch of how-tos guiding readers on how to replicate projects others have had success with. These practical guides are important and other projects that delve deeper into teaching people how to navigate society as a certain identity or to come to a deeper understanding of the world.

To instill knowledge and to contribute to an understanding of a movement is powerful, and if you have the opportunity to do that, just take it.

Ethos of DIY



Community-Centric

In DIY, the act of creation is not for your own ego or to build your reputation. It's not to generate income or to even make it in your field.

It's to bring about renewed joy, wisdom, and resistance to your community so that you and everyone around you can live better in it together.



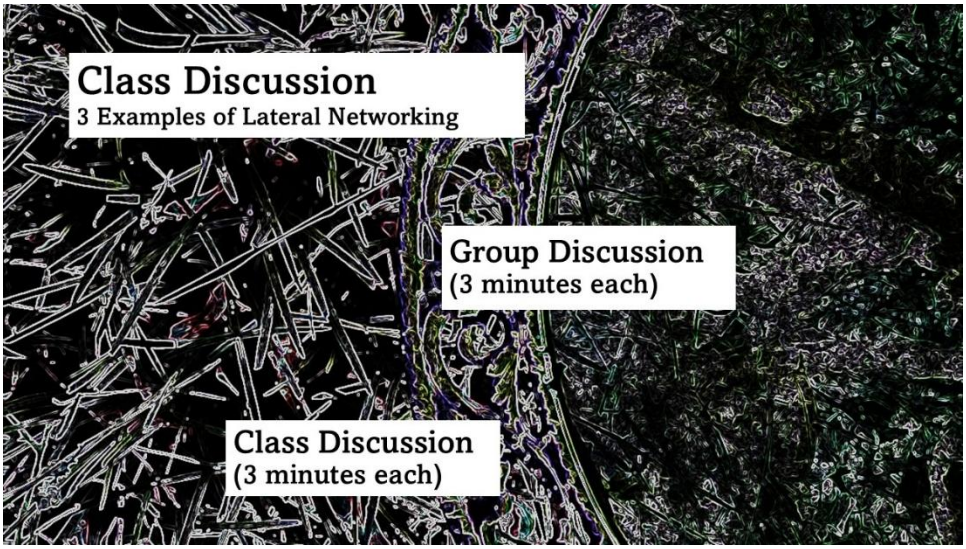
Other Ethos of DIY

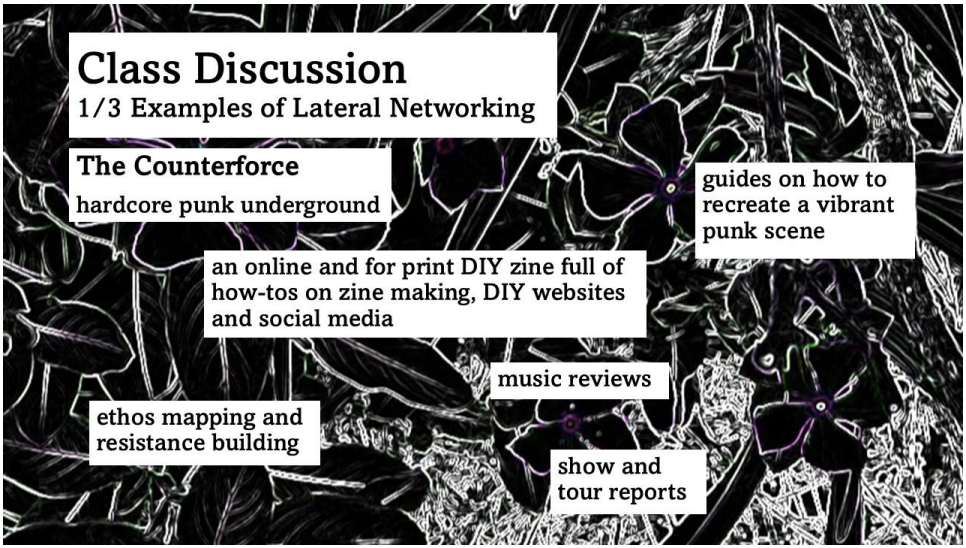
Other ethos of DIY may purposefully limit the scope and audience of the project. This gives it a niche target and appeal.

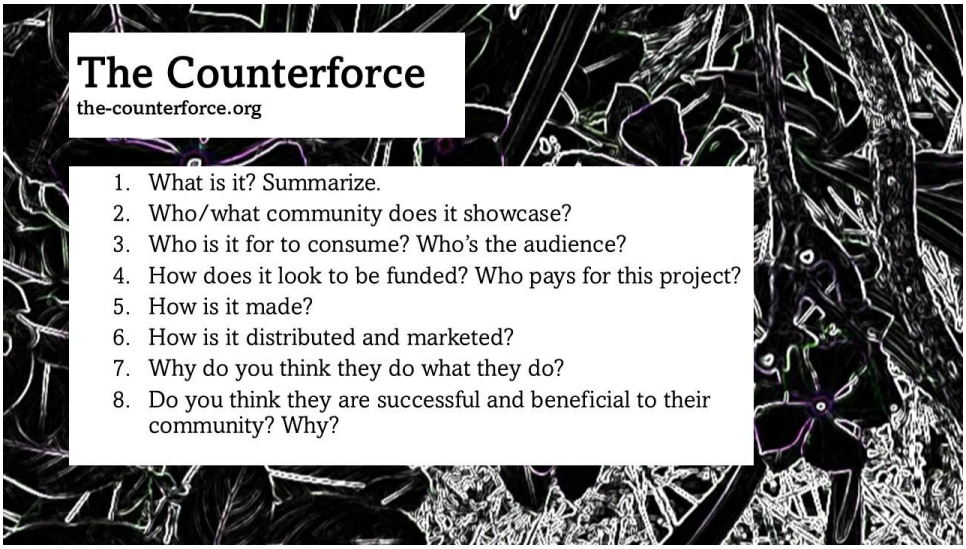
It can bring attention and support to marginalized communities and do justice for subjects that are repressed, ignored, forgotten.

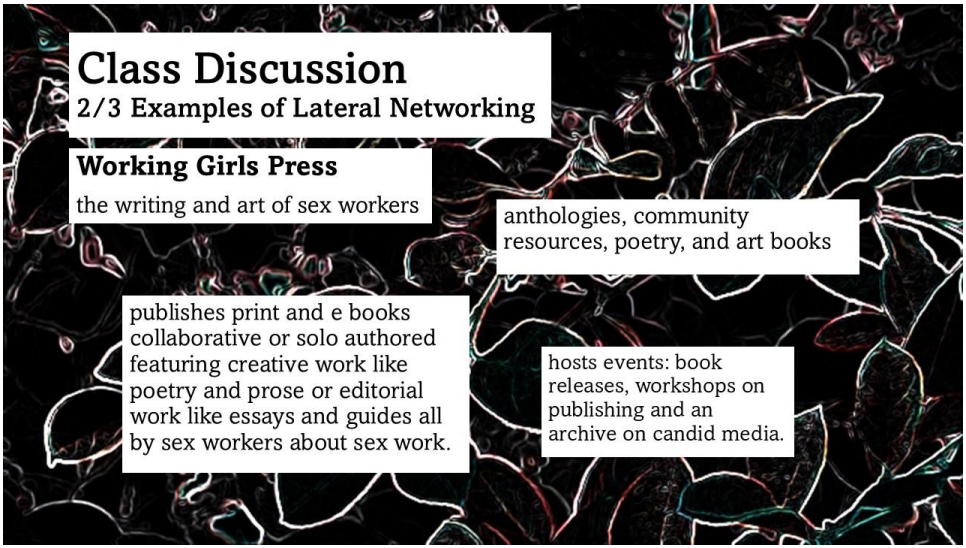
examples:

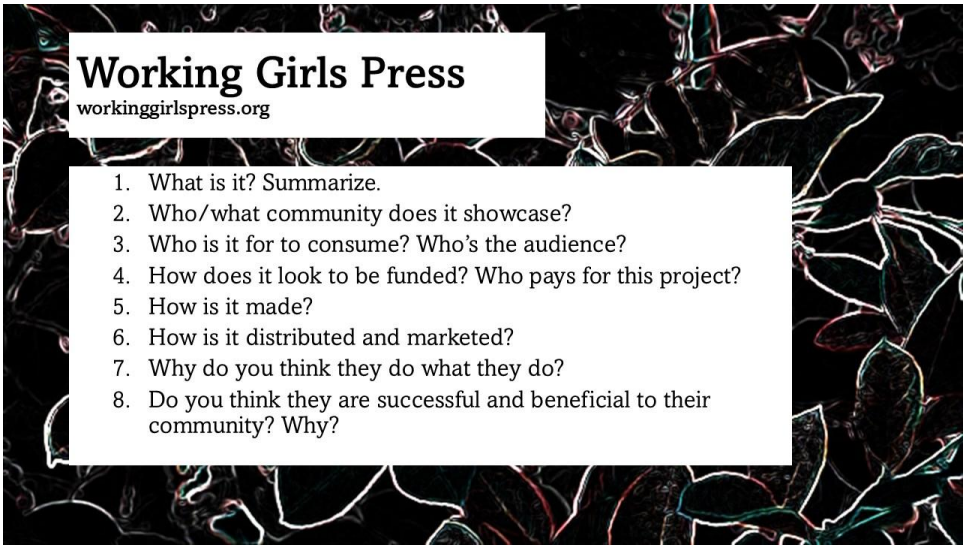
- a local area for the local community
- language preservation for those speakers
- women in the punk community (riot grrrl)
- navigating society as an LGBTQ+ member

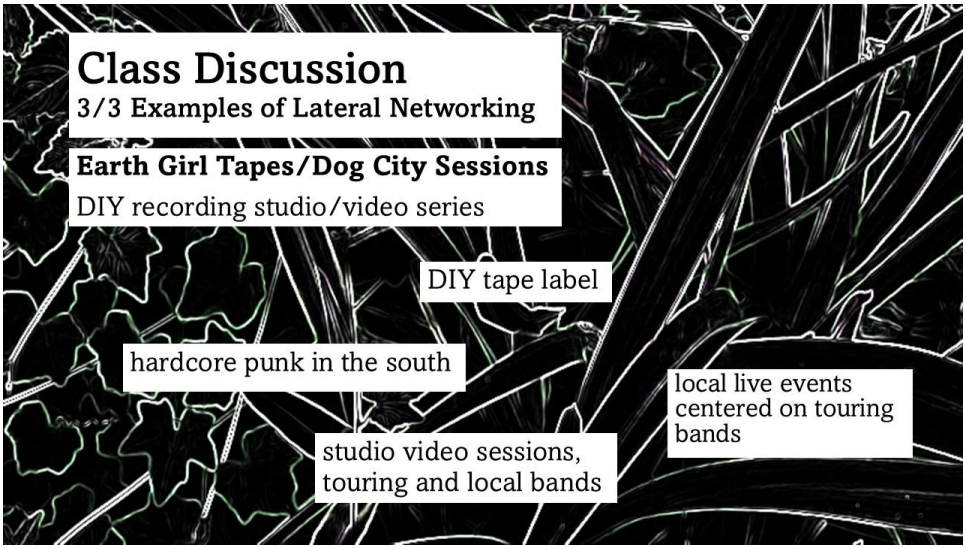

Class Discussion
3 Examples of Lateral Networking
Group Discussion
(3 minutes each)
Class Discussion
(3 minutes each)


Class Discussion
1/3 Examples of Lateral Networking
The Counterforce
hardcore punk underground
guides on how to recreate a vibrant punk scene
an online and for print DIY zine full of how-tos on zine making, DIY websites and social media
music reviews
ethos mapping and resistance building
show and tour reports


The Counterforce
the-counterforce.org
1. What is it? Summarize.
2. Who/what community does it showcase?
3. Who is it for to consume? Who's the audience?
4. How does it look to be funded? Who pays for this project?
5. How is it made?
6. How is it distributed and marketed?
7. Why do you think they do what they do?
8. Do you think they are successful and beneficial to their community? Why?


Class Discussion
2/3 Examples of Lateral Networking
Working Girls Press
the writing and art of sex workers
anthologies, community resources, poetry, and art books
publishes print and e books collaborative or solo authored featuring creative work like poetry and prose or editorial work like essays and guides all by sex workers about sex work.
hosts events: book releases, workshops on publishing and an archive on candid media.


Working Girls Press
workinggirlspress.org
1. What is it? Summarize.
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4. How does it look to be funded? Who pays for this project?
5. How is it made?
6. How is it distributed and marketed?
7. Why do you think they do what they do?
8. Do you think they are successful and beneficial to their community? Why?


Class Discussion
3/3 Examples of Lateral Networking
Earth Girl Tapes/Dog City Sessions
DIY recording studio/video series
DIY tape label
hardcore punk in the south
local live events centered on touring bands
studio video sessions, touring and local bands

Earth Girl Tapes/Dog City Sessions

earthgirltapes.bandcamp.com/music/youtube.com/@xliceheadx

1. What is it? Summarize.
2. Who/what community does it showcase?
3. Who is it for to consume? Who's the audience?
4. How does it look to be funded? Who pays for this project?
5. How is it made?
6. How is it distributed and marketed?
7. Why do you think they do what they do?
8. Do you think they are successful and beneficial to their community? Why?

HATTIESBURG ALTERNATIVE

Submissions based music, literature, and art zine.

zine: A zine is any sort of printed booklet, self-published and typically about a single topic by a single author and can cover any subject from art, music, and culture to political topics and social justice or any special interests like DIY hobbies, the sciences, history, and theories.

Submissions based: relies on entries from contributors who agree to allow their work to be printed in the zine.



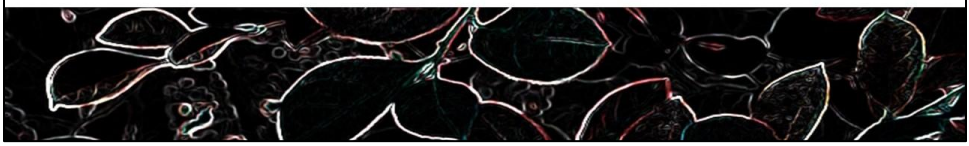


HATTIESBURG ALTERNATIVE

Framework

The framework I follow is called Do It Yourself or DIY. It's also becoming known as Do It Ourselves or DIO as we try to come together more often for a common goal.

DIY comes from or is at least adjacent to the punk scene and anarchist movement, and although punk and anarchy comes with a certain aesthetic and attitude, those aren't necessarily core beliefs or ethos of DIY.



HATTIESBURG ALTERNATIVE

Framework

Does using an anarchist framework limit the project's content or aesthetic?

No. Not at all.

Using a DIY framework, I'm able to pull inspiration from a variety of sources (literary journals, online blogs, art magazines) and reframe the material so it looks and functions differently.

As long as you stick to the ethos of DIY, you and your project culturally stays within the DIY and punk community.



HATTIESBURG ALTERNATIVE



Collecting Submissions

Collaborating with Artists

It's ok to reach out or approach artists or writers directly and ask for submissions or collaborations. If you approach artists, I recommending going up to artists or writers who you genuinely like and connect with rather than approaching someone because of their local fame or even the quality of their craft.

It's better to be on the same page as someone you're working with and form a genuine relationship rather than using them as a jumping off point.

HATTIESBURG ALTERNATIVE

Contracts

consent forms

When you are asking an artist collaborate with you, you need to define what you're asking of them, the nature of the product and your relationship, and how money will be transferred between yall.

For Hattiesburg Alternative, I have all contributors sign a consent form, which details exactly what they're allowing me to do with their work and protects me legally.



HATTIESBURG ALTERNATIVE



Consent and Release Form

Without expectation of compensation or other remuneration, now or in the future, I hereby give my consent to *Hattiesburg Alternative*, its affiliates and editors, to use my work, defined as: poem, short story, other creative written work, and/or my sketch, photo, drawing, painting, tattoo template, logo, and/or visual art in its publications, advertising or other media activities (including the Internet) in the Zine 6, Fall 2026 issue. This consent is limited to:

(a) Reproduction in physical and online publications

(b) Permission to use my name and the below information provided

(c) Digital storage; and

(d) Free and open to the public digital sharing of the zine for individual printing and distribution.

I also attest that the work was created by myself, I haven't used Artificial Intelligence at any capacity to create it, and I am at full liberty to give consent for it to be reproduced as submitted.

HATTIESBURG ALTERNATIVE

Other Content

Interviews
for artists and impactful community members

Show Reports
summaries of art and music events

Music and Project Reviews
reviews of new local releases

Upcoming Events
a list of upcoming events



HATTIESBURG ALTERNATIVE

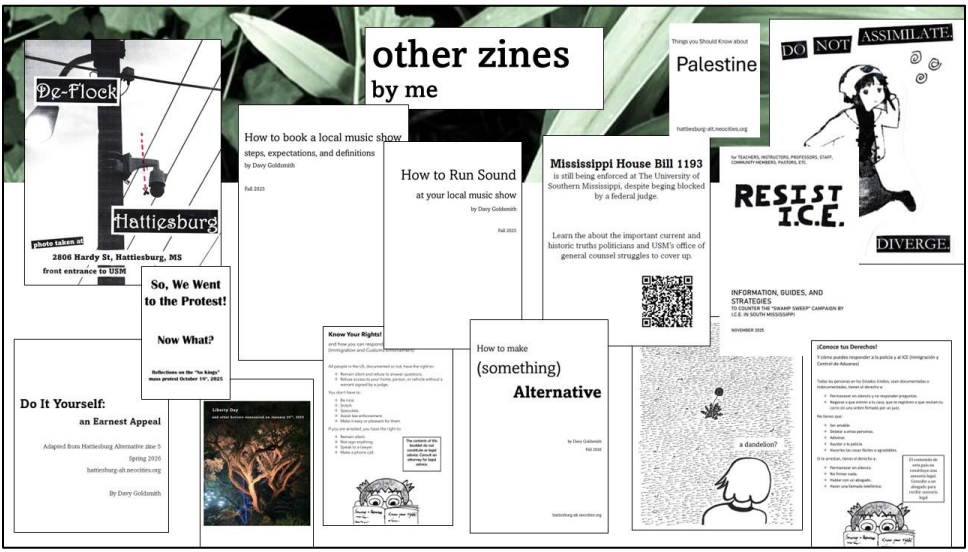


Other Content

Scene News
small insights on new projects coming up

Visitor's Log
visiting bands write about their experience here

Final Thoughts
Connecting the arts to larger America politically



DIY Resources

Resources used in DIY are low-cost and built to retain ownership of the product to the user.

This is why bandcamp is preferred over spotify.
ebay and fb marketplace over amazon.
The public library
DIY venues and spaces over bars and music venues



DIY Resources

This also applies to the preference of physical media

zines
cassette tapes
vhs
stickers
flyers
shirts
books
buttons



DIY Resources

and into the digital world as well

libre office over Microsoft office
proton.me over google mail and drive
Artcraft over adobe products
neocities.org and websites over wix
the fediverse over meta



DIY Resources

Libre Office

is a free to download series of programs that mimics and reads Microsoft office files.

proton.me

mimics google services such as mail, drive, and docs with encryption.



DIY Resources

"It's janky for now,
but it sort of works"

Artcraft

open source programs that mimic (vibe code) Adobe products.

photoshop – photocraft
illustrator – vectorcraft
premiere – filmcraft
lightroom - lightcraft

acrobat pro – printcraft
after effects – effectcraft
indesign – designcraft



DIY Resources

Neocities.org

Neocities is a webpage hosting site that teaches you and allows you to upload your own html code and host a website for free.



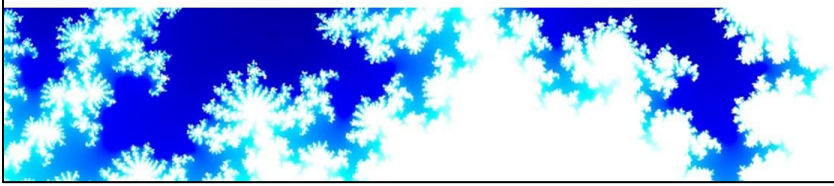
DIY Resources

other sites and open codes:

askapunk.net (Gancio): an interactive event calendar

faircamp: a web-based music player

the fediverse: an alternative social media network



DIY Resources: The Fediverse

Interoperable: accounts on different platforms can interact with each other. Imagine if twitter posts showed up on your insta feed. But Askapunk.net posts actually appear on your mastodon feed.

Decentralized: Accounts are hosted on an interactive network of thousands of servers of different sizes.

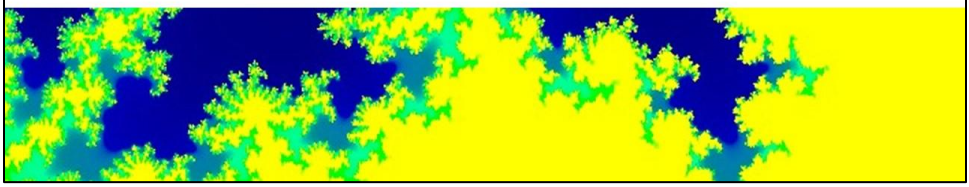
Federalized: cooperative and partially self-governing



DIY Resources: Home Servers

So many of these digital and online resources can be hosted completely on your own by setting up and using a home server.

Using a home server to host your own websites gives you a much larger degree of control and autonomy which encourages and promotes lateral networking over reliance on corporate services.



Mutual Aid

There were just now a lot of resources that you might not have the skillset to use yet.

This does not mean they're out of reach, just that now is the time to lean on lateral networking and ask for help in the form of mutual aid from your peers.

Mutual aid is an active part of lateral networking and is just helping people with their project that is neither transactional or charitable although it is needs based.



The opposite of Lateral Networking
and how to avoid it

The opposite of Lateral Networking is not Vertical networking, in which we appeal to people with more power or authority than us.

The opposite is In-Fighting, or sometimes known as Lateral Violence, in which we actively sabotage and destroy the connections and efforts of our peers.



In-Fighting

In-Fighting can be avoided by communication, grace, effort, and methods such as accountability and reconciliation.

Cutting peers out of your community and publicly calling them out is an act of In-Fighting because it does not hold them accountable and severs their connection to the group. However, if some of your peers are unsafe around the rest of yall or if they will not reconcile with you, that may be a good reason to sever ties with them.



Why Lateral Networking?

Lateral Networking pushes back against dependence on corporations and established norms.

> AI, data centers, globalization, and government-subsidized corporate ventures create a reliance on vertical networking with those already in power to retain that power through the dependance of consumers.

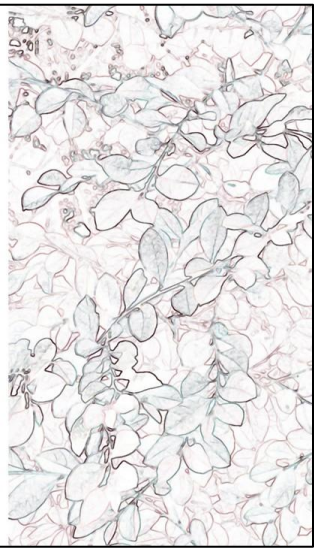
Lateral Networking through Mutual Aid is a tool to retain that power for creative, financial, and personal liberty.

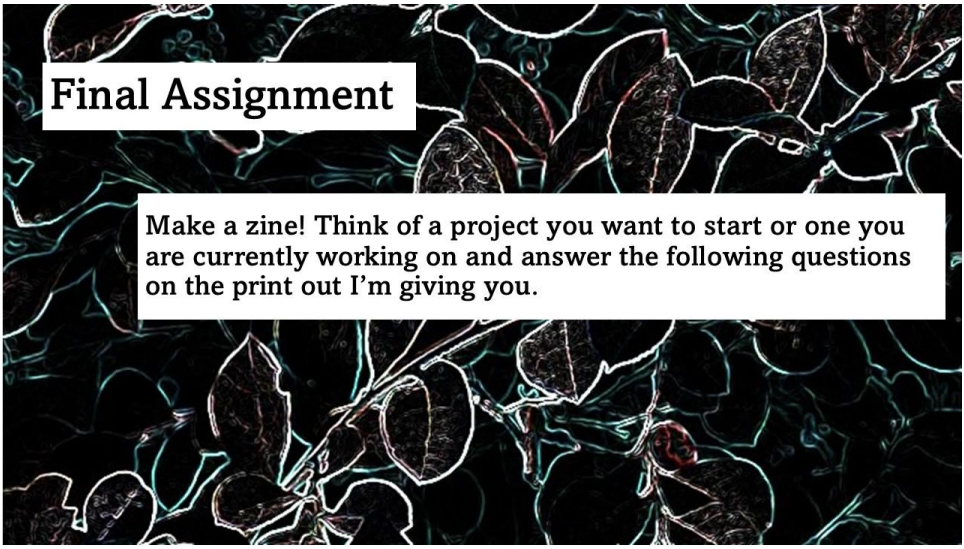


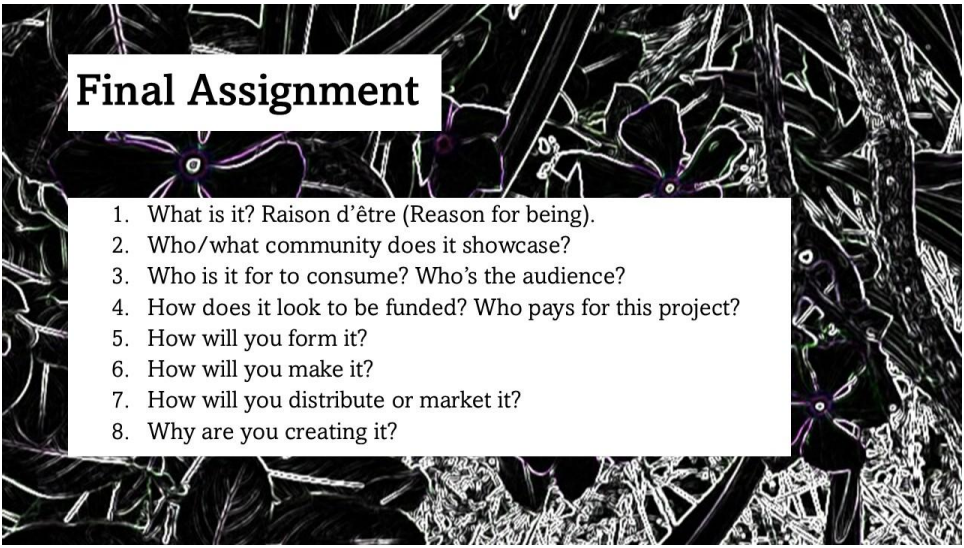
Why Lateral Networking?

When you begin looking for employment post-graduation, a good boss will value what you've been able to do on your own, how well you work with your peers, and what you learned in the process.

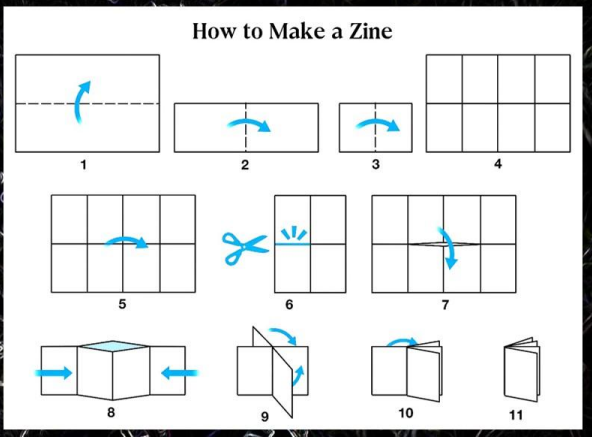
> Besides, it's good for your mental health and creative autonomy.




Final Assignment
Make a zine! Think of a project you want to start or one you are currently working on and answer the following questions on the print out I'm giving you.


Final Assignment
1. What is it? Raison d'être (Reason for being).
2. Who/what community does it showcase?
3. Who is it for to consume? Who's the audience?
4. How does it look to be funded? Who pays for this project?
5. How will you form it?
6. How will you make it?
7. How will you distribute or market it?
8. Why are you creating it?

Final Assignment



Write in and photocopy the next page and make one yourself!

Raison d'être (reason for being)

Why are you creating it?

What is it??

Who is it for to consume? Who's your audience?

Who/What community does it showcase?

How will it be funded? Who's paying for this project?

How will you form it?

How will you make it?

How will you distribute or market it?